



The bi-cultural option for global talent management: The Japanese/Brazilian *Nikkeijin* example



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ABSTRACT

This paper reports on an important subgroup of international boundary-spanners – immigrants and second or third generation migrants from the MNC's home country living in the subsidiary host country. We take as our example the *Nikkeijin* (Japanese immigrants and their descendants) in Brazil. Such bi-cultural people are a largely unexplored source of boundary-spanning internationally competent talent for multinational enterprises. Using two different surveys, we find that this group is recognized as a source of talent by Japanese MNCs, but that their HRM practices are not appropriate to attract and use them in their global talent management programmes.

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1. Introduction

Studies of international human resource management developed from an early concentration on expatriates assigned from parent-company headquarters to foreign subsidiaries (PCNs), to a wider analysis of the use of host country nationals (HCNs) and third-country nationals (TCNs) (Harzing, 1999, 2001; Scullion & Collings, 2006; Toh & DeNisi, 2005) and then more recently to self-initiated expatriates (see the recent books on the topic (Andresen, Al Ariss, Walther, & Wolff, 2012; Vaiman & Haslberger, 2012)). The latest area of interest has been in the management of international staff who fit none of these categories: the increasing number of the international labour force who, from birth or experience, are individuals who are capable in more than one culture. We explore this topic through an examination of a particular group of bi-culturals: Japanese Brazilians.

The reasons for the use of expatriates were originally described as three-fold (Edström & Galbraith, 1977): To compensate for a

lack of skills amongst the foreign workforce, as a means of control or developing the organization by transferring knowledge and policies, or as a means of developing individual expatriates. This categorization has stood the test of time and is still used today, though augmented with other purposes such as developing global mindsets (Arora, Jaju, Kefalas, & Perenich, 2004; Osland, Bird, Mendenhall, & Osland, 2006). While expatriation makes a positive contribution to organizational objectives, there are also disadvantages: The chief amongst these is the cost – usually several times the cost of the appointment of the same individual on their home site and many times more than the cost of employing locals. They may also have very little understanding of the foreign business context, may have problems with the local language and with settling into and performing effectively in the local environment. Whilst the importance of pre-departure training programmes to improve the cross-cultural adjustment of expatriates and their family member has been emphasized in the IHRM literature for years, researchers are unable to prove its effectiveness (Ehnert & Brewster, 2008; Puck, Kittler, & Wright, 2008; Tarique & Caligiuri, 2009). Moreover, the successful reintegration of former expatriates is one of the troublesome challenges in the global assignment cycle (Brewster, Sparrow, Vernon, & Houldsworth, 2011; Mendenhall, Dunbar, & Oddou, 1987; Tung, 1988).

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